

The Other Side of the Case: A DEA Agent Looks Back on His Most Personal Investigation

Agent Hank Schrader opens up about the hunt for the drug maker known as Heisenberg, and the truth he never saw coming

By Zac Scarpa | The Albuquerque Journal

ALBUQUERQUE, N.M. - Henry "Hank" Schrader spent years chasing a drug kingpin the streets only knew as Heisenberg. He closed more cases than almost anyone else in the DEA's Albuquerque field office. He survived a near-fatal shooting. He gave the case everything he had. But in the end, the biggest shock was not catching Heisenberg. It was finding out who he really was.

Schrader sat down to talk about the Heisenberg case from start to finish. He spoke about the moments that shaped the investigation, the signs he missed along the way, and what it cost him in the end.

When asked when the case stopped feeling like just a job, Schrader pointed to a shooting in a grocery store parking lot. Two cartel-linked men attacked him in broad daylight. He was hit four times and spent months in recovery, relearning how to walk. The attack left physical scars, but Schrader says the mental toll was worse. He began to work alone, cut corners, and pull away from his team.

"When you survive something like that, when you stare down death and somehow come out the other side, you start thinking you're invincible," he said. "I thought getting attacked meant I was getting close to something big. So I pushed harder, cut corners, isolated myself from the people who could've helped me do this the right way."

Looking back, Schrader does not let himself off the hook. He listed the warning signs he now sees clearly but ignored at the time. A gas mask went missing from his office after a ride-along. A car blew up under odd circumstances. A phone call pulled him away from a key search at just the wrong moment. Unexplained money flowed into a household with no clear source for it.

"Every single time, I'd think about it for half a second and then... I'd push it away," he said. "Because it was Walt. Gentle, nerdy, wouldn't-hurt-a-fly Walt. The guy brings me mineral samples from his classroom like a puppy looking for approval."

Schrader said one of the biggest things he missed was a shift in Walt's behavior. The man he had known for years was quiet and easy to push around. Over time, he became more sure of himself. At the time, Schrader thought it was a good thing. He says he mistook the change for personal growth.

"He went from this meek, scared little guy to confident. Assertive. Almost cocky sometimes," Schrader said. "And I thought, good for him, beating cancer, finding his strength. Turns out he wasn't finding his strength. He was finding his power. And I mistook a man turning into a monster for a man finally growing a spine."

The moment Schrader says everything clicked was not in the field. It was in a bathroom. He picked up a copy of Walt Whitman's "Leaves of Grass" at Walt's house and found a short note inside with initials he had seen before, in the notebook of a dead chemist connected to Heisenberg's operation.

"My hands started shaking," he said. "And then everything starts clicking into place like dominoes. I knew. Deep in my gut, I knew. But I also knew that if I was right, my entire world was about to come crashing down."

He described sitting with that realization and what it meant not just for the case, but for his family.

"Everything I thought I knew about Walter White," he said quietly, "it was all a lie."

Few parts of the story are harder for Schrader to talk about than what happened to his marriage. His wife, Marie, tried to support him through the panic attacks and the long recovery. But as the case took over more of his time and focus, he became harder to reach. He turned their garage into a workspace full of files and boxes. He was physically home but not present.

"She'd come out to that garage and just... look at me like she didn't know who I was anymore," he said. "And the worst part? When I finally figured it out about Walt, I couldn't even tell her. Had to keep it from her to protect the case. So there I am, sitting on the biggest secret of our lives, and I can't share it with my own wife."

When asked whether, knowing how things would end, he would have walked away from the case, Schrader did not hesitate.

"No. Hell no. There's not a chance in hell I could've walked away," he said. "Walt didn't just cook meth. He sat at my dinner table. He let my wife comfort his wife. My nephew looked up to him like a father figure. He looked me in the eye, hundreds of times, and lied."

He did not stop there.

"I'd rather die doing the right thing than live knowing I let Walter White walk free," he said. "At least I got him to admit it. Got him to say my name and know that I beat him. That I figured it out."

Hank Schrader's story is not just about a drug case. It is about a lawman who followed the truth even when it led somewhere painful. He paid a high price for it. And he says he would do it all over again.

The Heisenberg case is closed. The blue meth is gone from the streets. But for the people left behind, some things are not so easy to move past.

Schrader leaned back in his chair as the interview came to a close.

"I was a damn good agent," he said. "I just never thought I'd need to look in my own brother-in-law's direction."

This heartbreaking story goes to show that drugs and the world surrounding them do not just affect those who directly touch them, but their friends, their families, and their loved ones, even if they have to live an entirely different life before bringing that burden on them.